MAICON

FORWARD

Oct. 13-15, 2026

www.MAICON.ai

(AI-Generated Session Notes)

What's Actually Working: AI Across the Advertising Funnel

Date & time: Oct. 15, 10:00-10:35 AM
Track: Applied AI



Alec Foster

Chief Agent Officer & Responsible AI Lead, Marketing, Media Alliance (MMA)

- LinkedIn
- X

Session Description

Everyone talks about AI in advertising. Few have the data to back it up. MMA's Future Labs has run 100+ controlled experiments across advertising, AI search visibility, and media measurement. This session focuses on the ad funnel, with results from global brands including Kroger, AT&T, General Motors, Shell, and The Home Depot.

We'll walk through what actually moves the needle. Pre-launch creative scoring that predicts performance before a dollar is spent. Audience discovery that surfaces high-response cohorts invisible to traditional targeting. AI-generated video creative that matches or beats traditionally produced spots. Contextual targeting that reads page meaning through LLM embeddings across a 4-billion-URL index. And creative personalization averaging +160% lift.

Every result comes from a live campaign with real media spend and a documented design. You'll leave knowing which AI use cases deliver measurable impact today, which are still maturing, and how to judge what fits your own media mix.

Key Quote

> *"Making an ad saves production time, but whether it sells better is something that you have to test."*
> **- Alec Foster**

Session Summary

Alec Foster, Chief Agent Officer and Responsible AI Lead at Marketing, Media Alliance (MMA), shared results from the controlled experiments MMA runs with enterprise brands through its AI Leadership Think Tank. His central message was that the biggest wins from AI in advertising predate generative AI: they come from deciding who sees which ad, and when and where, often using creative the brand already has. He also urged the audience to check how every reported result was produced, since a live campaign measured against a control group deserves more trust than a model prediction, a pilot, or a pre-test.

Foster started at the optimization end of the funnel with CAP, MMA's longest-running lab, which has run about 29 experiments with 18 brands since 2022. The brand keeps its approved creative

and AI chooses which version each person sees, while a control group sees the same versions at random. Results included 259% more web page visits for Kroger, 272% more buy flow conversions and 88% more sales for AT&T, and 161% more app registrations for Shell in the UK. A GM test optimized for brand perception raised favorability by 8.7% and purchase intent by 7.9%.

Two newer optimization labs build on this. Aura shifts budget week by week toward the audience groups that respond best, with early pilots showing about a 22% average lift. Mocha, run with RMT Labs and drawing on neuroscience research from Wharton, tests whether an ad works harder when the audience and the viewing context match the motivation already in the creative.

Moving up the funnel, MMA's AI Creative Effectiveness (ACE) lab, run with VidMob, pre-scores creative against a brand's own performance history; a model trained on 1,934 Kroger ads sorted high and low converters correctly about 81% of the time. On generative creative, Foster said AI agents can take a brief to a finished video and cut production time and cost, but an outside Ipsos and Syracuse University study found AI ads held their own on simple product-led jobs while human ads still won on emotional storytelling. He also described GASP, a new lab that brings holdout groups to AEO and GEO testing.

Foster closed with why some tests fell short: platform settings nobody checked, KPIs that did not track with sales, too little variety between ad versions, and tests that ended early or lost their internal sponsor. His checklist for running your own tests calls for a defined control group, one sales-validated KPI set before launch, constant creative, budget, and dates, and a named owner who decides whether to scale or stop.

Key Takeaways

- **Targeting decisions beat new creative:** MMA's biggest lifts came from AI deciding who sees which ad, when, and where, often using ads the brand already had.
- **Check how the number was measured:** Results from live campaigns with a control group deserve more trust than model predictions, pilots, or pre-tests, so ask vendors what a lift was compared to, on which KPI, and over what period.
- **Optimize for KPIs that track sales:** Clicks and video completion rate can rise without moving sales, so choose one KPI that has been checked against sales data before launch.
- **Give the AI real choices:** Ad versions need meaningful differences in color, message, and theme, because near-identical variations produced much smaller lift.
- **Match generative AI to the job:** AI-made ads performed well for product demos and simple product-led messages, while human-made ads still won on emotional, story-driven work.
- **Set tests up to finish:** Lock the brief, confirm platform settings, have data ready on day one, and keep a sponsor in place through the end of the test.